weakening of the Hindu–Muslim revolutionary bond in India. Even in Afghanistan relations appeared to have settled into something of their old routine, with the Afghan ruler busily courting first one and then the other of his neighbours for his own gains. By 1923 then, affairs in South Asia had stabilised.

And while part of this improvement in Britain's foreign relations can be attributed to the pragmatism of the likes of Loraine and Reading, undoubtedly this change was also helped along by the relative failure of the Bolshevik regime to attain their goals in Persia and Afghanistan. Despite all the anti-Bolshevik rhetoric of 1918–1919, by 1922 it was clear that Lenin and his colleagues were struggling just as much as Britain was with pan-Islamism and nationalism. Superficially Moscow was still capable of stirring up trouble for Britain through its anti-imperialist propaganda and sponsoring of men such as M.N. Roy. However, it was becoming increasingly apparent that beneath all this bluster, the Bolsheviks were struggling to recruit to the Communist cause. On a diplomatic level, Asia's rulers were proving almost as disloyal and adept at self-preservation as the Bolsheviks themselves were, while at the grass-roots, the failure to create many fully-fledged Communists out of the milieu of Asian revolutionaries was limiting the extent to which the Bolsheviks could really infiltrate the region. While the emir of Afghanistan or the shah of Persia would always find flirting with the Soviet government (and thus irritating the British) an enjoyable pastime, there remained an invisible barrier of caution surrounding these rulers. Decades of British and Russian intrigue in this region of the world had taught these nations to be wary of allowing either of their powerful neighbours to get too close, whatever placations and promises the new leaders in Moscow might give.

The failure of the Soviet government to make great revolutionary headway in South Asia by 1922-23 was particularly important as it meant that when the likes of Loraine advocated a detached policy in Persia, London was more inclined to listen than it had been in 1918. Despite Curzon's previous claims, Britain's failure to extend its influence in this region had not portended the Bolshevik apocalypse. There therefore seemed no harm in now following a policy in Persia and Afghanistan that appeared to involve less effort and less risk than what Britain had been doing hitherto. Curzon's